

CORE FORMULA

Meaningful moment + warm pause + one useful next move. -> Say the key sentence, pause, let them continue, then reflect or ask one useful question. -> "That sounds like it mattered." [pause] "What part is still with you?" -> "My recommendation is option B." [pause] "What concerns would you have?" -> "I can do Friday, but not Thursday." [pause] "Would Friday still help?" -> "What part of this feels most unresolved?" [pause]

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Say the key sentence or question, then pause warmly for one slow breath before speaking again.

BEST FOR

- After a meaningful question about values, feelings, trade-offs, concern, or commitment.
- After someone shares something vulnerable, surprising, difficult, or important.
- After a reflection, label, validation, or summary check.
- In negotiation, after a calibrated question.
- In conflict, when emotion needs a moment to settle.
- After a clear recommendation, boundary, or clean request.
- In social or dating conversation, when a moment has emotional weight.

PHRASE BANK

Supportive pause openers · Supportive pause openers

- "Take your time."
- "No rush."
- "I am with you."
- "I am just thinking for a second."
- "You do not have to answer immediately."
- "Let that sit for a moment."

After emotion · After emotion

- "That sounds like it hit hard."
- "I do not want to rush past that."
- "That sounds like it stayed with you."
- "What part is still sitting with you?"
- "That makes sense that you needed a second."
- "There is no rush to put words to it."

After a question · Ask, then hold the pause

- "What was the real issue there? [pause]"
- "What do you make of that? [pause]"
- "What would make this workable? [pause]"
- "What are you worried I am not seeing? [pause]"
- "What does your instinct say? [pause]"

Professional · Work, meetings, recommendations

- "I will pause there because that is the key trade-off."
- "I do not want to over-talk the recommendation."
- "I will stop there and hear your concern."

- "Bottom line: I recommend X. [pause]"
- "What is your reaction? [pause]"
- "Let me put the option on the table and then hear you."

Conflict / tension · Heat, pressure, disagreement

- "I hear the concern. [pause]"
- "I do not want to respond too quickly and miss the point."
- "Take a second. What feels most unresolved?"
- "I am not ignoring you — I am trying not to react too fast."
- "That is a fair thing to pause on."
- "Let us both take a breath before we carry on."

High-status / busy · Concise, invites challenge

- "I will keep it brief and pause there."
- "Your read? [pause]"
- "What would you challenge? [pause]"
- "I will stop there rather than over-explain."
- "Happy to be challenged. [pause]"

Digital / text · Messages and email

- "No need to reply quickly — worth thinking about."
- "Leaving that with you rather than over-explaining."
- "Take your time. A short reply is fine."
- "I will stop there so this does not become a wall of text."
- "Happy to pause there and hear your reaction."

Recovery · Softening a pause that landed wrong

- "Sorry, I went quiet because I was thinking, not judging."
- "That pause probably felt more intense than I meant."
- "I did not want to rush past that, but we can move on."
- "I am not trying to put you on the spot."
- "I was giving that space, but I may have overdone it."
- "No pressure to answer quickly."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Uses the technique mechanically or too often.
Better: Uses the smallest useful version and then listens.
Best: Uses it only when the cue is present, keeps the wording natural, and adjusts to the response.
2. Weak: Talks about the technique instead of doing it.
Better: Performs one clear behavioural move.
Best: Makes the move feel like ordinary skilled conversation.
3. Weak: Fills every gap with words to kill the silence.
Better: Lets one pause land after the key point.
Best: Treats silence as a normal, comfortable part of the exchange.

DECISION TREE

If They continue with more detail

Stay quiet, listen, then reflect the new information back.
"So the real concern is the ongoing ownership, not the task itself."

If They go thoughtful and quiet

Hold the pause a little longer, then offer a gentle prompt.
"What are you thinking?"

If They look uncomfortable or exposed

Soften immediately and give them an exit.

"No pressure — we can move on."

If They ask what you mean

Clarify. The silence probably followed something too vague.

"Let me say that more clearly."

If They become defensive

Return to validation or autonomy release.

"It is completely your call — I just wanted to understand it."

If They turn the question back to you

Answer briefly, then hand the thread back to them.

"Short version from me, then I want your take."

SCENARIOS

A friend shares something painful

Reflect briefly, then pause and let them lead. — "That sounds like it stayed with you. [pause] What part is still sitting with you?"

Making a professional recommendation

Make the recommendation once, then stop. — "My recommendation is option B because it reduces risk. I will pause there — what concerns would you have?"

Conflict

Validate, pause, then clarify the real issue. — "I can see why that felt unfair. [pause] What part felt most unfair?"

Negotiation

Ask a calibrated question and let it sit. — "How could we make that work with the timeline? [pause]"

High-status or busy person

Be concise and do not over-justify. — "Bottom line: I would choose X. Happy to be challenged. [pause]"

Shy or guarded person

Use a shorter pause plus an exit. — "No rush. You do not have to go into it if you would rather not."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- Immediate safety or operational urgency requires clear action.
- The person already feels abandoned, embarrassed, confused, or put on the spot.
- You would be using silence to punish, dominate, extract, test, or create discomfort.
- The relationship depth is low and the pause becomes too intense.
- A simple direct answer would be more respectful.
- You are performing calm rather than genuinely listening.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Notice the urge

Through the day, just notice the moments you rush to fill a silence. Change nothing yet — count how often you fill gaps.

Day 2 — One slow breath

After asking a meaningful question, count one slow breath before speaking again. Do it at least twice today.

Day 3 — Recommend and stop

In one professional conversation, make your recommendation once and stop before adding extra justifications.

Day 4 — Reflect, pause, wait

In one supportive conversation, reflect once, pause, and let the person continue before asking anything else.

Day 5 — Warm the pause

Practise keeping a soft face and open posture during a pause so it reads as space, not coldness. Add "take your time" if needed.

Day 6 — Recover cleanly

When a pause lands awkwardly, use one recovery line — "I went quiet because I was thinking, not judging" — and carry on.

Day 7 — Space vs pressure review

Review the week. For each attempt, note whether the silence felt like space or pressure, and what made the difference.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I pause after a moment that had weight?
- Did my silence feel warm rather than cold?
- Did I avoid rescuing the other person too quickly?
- Did I clarify if the pause became awkward?
- Did I use silence to create space, not pressure?
- Did the other person become more open, thoughtful, or specific?